

Cultural Studies, Popular Culture, and Pedagogy

A. Overview and Background

In England, where cultural studies originated, its disciplinary center was sociology. Perhaps most influential to the later American development of the field was Stuart Hall, a Black sociologist who directed, for a time, the Center for Contemporary Cultural Studies in Birmingham.¹ In its inception, cultural studies grew out of the experience of educating working-class people with a commitment to the political applications of knowledge and criticism; it was also therefore committed to a kind of theorizing and critical practice that had social change as one of its goals. It took as its object of study the everyday culture and practices of people.

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According to Grossberg, Nelson, and Treichler, the editors of the influential anthology *Cultural Studies*, the term “cultural studies” covers a range of theoretical and political positions that use a variety of methodologies, drawing on **ethnography**, anthropology, sociology, literature, feminism, Marxism, history, film criticism, psychoanalysis, and semiotics. Cultural studies is anthropological, but unlike anthropology, it begins with the study of postindustrial rather than preindustrial societies. It is like **humanism**, but unlike traditional humanism it rejects the distinction between so-called low culture and high culture and argues that all forms of culture need to be studied in relation to a given social formation (4). It is thus interdisciplinary in its approaches. Cultural studies “has grown out of efforts to understand what has shaped post World War II societies and cultures: industrialization, modernization, urbanization, mass communication, commodification, **imperialism**, a global economy” (5).

I am using the concept of “popular,” with which cultural studies is largely concerned, to talk about the everyday terrain of people without being sure who the people are, that is, without deciding ahead of time and once and for all who is being referred to by the term “people.” I am also using it in the sense of “mass” culture, the popular cultural forms produced through the medium of mass technology and communications, as well as those forms produced on a smaller, localized scale. I will continue in this work the traditional focus of cultural studies on the disempowered or marginalized within a dominant culture and the ways struggles for power are conducted through representations. These groups are sometimes called subcultures (originally a term used in Britain to refer to youth cultures): cultural formations within the dominant culture that can be distinguished by a stance, a style, an attitude, a position, and a fashion as defiant, resistant, or oppositional to what is viewed as the dominant culture.³ But the focus here will also be on the ways mainstream culture reacts to, defines, and represents certain subcultures.

What distinguishes cultural studies, above all, from other fields is that it has a commitment to examining cultural practices from the point of view of their entanglement with, and within, relations of power. That is where politics comes in: cultural studies is not a “politically neutral” discipline. It is also a bridge between theory and material cul-

ture, and a focus on the social difference that theory can make (*Cultural Studies*, 6). Analysis depends on intellectual work; but intellectual work is incomplete unless it enters back into the world of cultural and political power struggles. This book thus is not about the transcendence of art, its universality, its message to all humankind; it is about the relationship between cultural artifacts (movies, videos, science fiction books, comic strips, pornography, popular novels, popular science, performance art) and our social order; and it is also about various “subcultures” in the United States and their cultural productions. A cultural studies approach seeks to understand what culture has to do with the economic, political, and social forces that structure and order our lives depending on who we are and where we are located in the social order. Another way of referring to this positioning is “situatedness,” or someone’s “subject position,” as empowered, disempowered, permitted, proscribed, visible, invisible, privileged, discriminated against, and so forth.⁴

As Michele Wallace (*Invisibility Blues*) and bell hooks (*Yearning*) argue, the representation of marginalized groups of people or subcultures in mass media has become a major arena of contestation in our culture. hooks points out that representatives of these groups of people have less access to the production of such images, and thus one way to have a voice is to challenge the dominant culture’s representation of themselves. Both hooks and Wallace complain that much of this criticism takes the form of talking about “good” or “bad” images, which treats representation as a reflection of fact and suggests that there is one accurate way to represent a person from a minority group or a marginalized group. And to do this is to immediately buy in to the logic of stereotypes—that is, the logic of racism, sexism, or homophobia—by accepting the mass media’s capacity to “represent” a group of people.

One of the challenges in dealing with media representation is not only to decide whether representations are good or bad, but to analyze them. What work are they doing? What motivates the representation? What does this representation say about the representers and the imagined viewers of such a representation? What elements are combined in a cultural representation? What contradictions get highlighted?

Asking some of these questions is a way into a cultural studies analysis of a mass media-produced visual text. How does it speak about the social context that produces it? Michele Wallace's remarks on close reading and context are useful here: "however 'close' that reading may be, it won't provide much information about how literature by black women alternately conspires with and rebels against our present cultural and political arrangements."⁵ Thus she calls for "cultural reading" (656) as an act of resistance, whereby cultural productions are consistently tied by the reader to social, historical, and political contexts.

The question of the politics of any popular culture text—whether or not it challenges dominant ideas about the culture—is always difficult, and it often risks becoming a version of the good and bad representation issue; but we may still explore the possibilities and limits of such texts. In order to be truly popular, texts must appeal across a broad range of political and subject positions. For example, until recently, the mass culture industry did not seem to realize that Black culture was a marketable commodity and that there were enough middle-class African American consumers to constitute a serious consumer population.⁶ Racism functioned in a very contradictory manner here: because market analysts thought white people would not be interested in Black films or Black music, there was very little of it in Hollywood or on MTV; because they thought all African Americans were poor, they also didn't think there was enough of a Black consumer market for Black films, Black ads, Black MTV. Now the industry knows it was mistaken. One could describe this as a positive or negative development, and in fact it is both. On the one hand, protests from Black constituents and the entry of African Americans into Hollywood as directors forced a change in the industry. On the other hand, Black culture has now become a commodity like any other, one that does not, by and large, profit African Americans. This commodification, by managing race relations, increases the possibilities for control as well.

Popular culture representations, in their most popular or mass form, often bear contradictions within them and send very mixed political messages, covert messages, or even unconscious messages, so that a variety of people can consent to them. Consider why some movies have failed to attract a large market, and you will see that it is

often because the politics were too clear or the message too extreme. This is mostly true for representations that are oppositional, that is, representations that take an unpopular stand against widely held beliefs or political positions in the culture.⁷ This also explains why it is still possible to make very racist or sexist movies: there is still enough of a constituency to support such representations in the culture, and the people targeted do not yet have enough visibility or voice to challenge the representations in question. What, then, are popular culture's possibilities for challenging the social order? What limits these possibilities, and why?

As Stuart Hall argues, cultural studies “has to analyze certain things about the constitutive and political nature of representation itself, about its complexities, about the effects of language, about textuality as a site of life and death.”⁸ By “the constitutive nature of representation” he means the way representations (visual, aural, verbal, etc.) actually construct their object, so that rather than talking about good or bad images of something that exists “out there” in its true or authentic state, we need to talk about how an image constructs what it is representing. We have to pretend, in a way, that we do not know what that object is (a lesbian, for example, in a film such as *Basic Instinct*), and we must ask, how does this representation construct lesbian identity? The political nature of representation may be a clearer concept to grasp: how, for example, do representations affect the lives of the people and situations they represent? How do they influence decision making about their subject matter? (Take the *Murphy Brown* show, for example; or *The Silence of the Lambs*—how does this representation of a pseudo-transsexual man influence the politics of queer struggle for rights and recognition?)

This project is also about changing our position as “mere” consumers of mass culture and making us into critics, meaning that we approach our culture critically and we analyze it, not only in order to denounce it, but in order to understand the ways it works on us, the ways we are implicated in it. It is about understanding how our culture represents us and how we are represented in it. Thus, this kind of analysis also always involves locating oneself as analyst: what is your subject position; how are you situated in relation to it and by it (how does it situate a person as consumer, reader, viewer, participant,

addressee); how is any given representation about you, speaking to you or for you, that is, how does it construct you as the consumer of that representation? This is an easier critical consciousness for some than for others. For example, as hooks says, there has always been a tradition of critical consciousness in African American communities in the United States because of U.S. policies explicitly disenfranchising such communities. If you know that the dominant culture is not “for” you or “about” you, it is easier for you to view it with a critical eye. So too, says hooks, it becomes difficult to be critical of (to critique) a representation when it is produced by “one of your own” (she gives the example of Spike Lee), because the representation claims to speak for you and about you, in your name and in your interests. But whether the work is easy or hard, critiquing is one of the most important things to do.⁹

We also, all of us, change subject positions. There are times when we will be explicitly “othered” by a representation, just as there are times when a representation is for us and “others” someone else. The point is to be aware of this rather than unreflectively responding to it. Here is where the concept of “interpellation” or “hailing,” developed by the French Marxist philosopher Louis Althusser, is very helpful. It refers to how a social formation constructs us as subjects who respond and consent to it in certain ways. It is a description of how ideology functions, not by persuading us with rational argument to believe that something is true, but by manufacturing our consent to certain ideas by representing them as self-evident reality.¹⁰

John Fiske’s essay “Cultural Studies and the Culture of Everyday Life” introduces some of the key notions in cultural studies: the idea of culture as the culture of everyday life; the idea of the *habitus* or social space that locates us in terms of cultural and economic capital, education, class, and history (*Cultural Studies*, 155). He makes the important point that material, everyday lived culture is a contradictory mixture of creativity and constraint: “The social order constrains and oppresses the people, but at the same time offers them resources to fight against those constraints” (157). Elizabeth Young’s essay “*The Silence of the Lambs* and the Playing of Feminist Theory” illustrates what Fiske is talking about: how the film offers creative critiques and possibilities for the questioning of gender even as it constrains and op-

presses us within its models of gender.¹¹ “The constraints,” Fiske writes, “are material, economic ones which determine, in an oppressive, disempowering way, the limits of the social experience of the poor. Oppression is always economic. Yet the everyday culture of the oppressed takes the signs of that which oppresses them and uses them for its own purposes” (157). Here we might want to think about how classic Hollywood representations of the ultimate in femininity, Marilyn Monroe, for example, become cult and camp icons for gay male subcultures, who often feature drag performances of these famous Hollywood stars.

Fiske also discusses the body as the site of social control (161–62). To say that the body is a site of social control is to make the point, first and foremost, that the body is not some kind of natural biological entity, but an artifact, a socially constructed, socially situated body acted on by a host of interrelated **power-knowledges**. This concept was popularized by the French historian and philosopher Michel Foucault, who analyzed how social formations organize technologies of power and knowledge (psychiatry, police, prisons, hospitals, medicine, science, universities, governments) that are mapped onto bodies and construct us as subjects.¹² The body is no longer conceived of as a bundle of raw instincts and impulses that law, order, and government are supposed to discipline but that always threatens to break loose; rather, the technologies of discipline and surveillance construct us as beings who think we are “repressed” and in need of sexual “liberation,” in order to create an economy of management and social control. Serial killer movies, which I will be discussing later, illustrate this managed, surveilled body very well, by linking together representations of the police, psychiatry, knowledge, power, and techniques of surveillance.¹³

Thus, for example, we come to believe that sex is an arena of transgression and liberation as opposed to order and reason; we come to believe that we must discipline ourselves to be productive citizens, and yet that abandoning ourselves to sexual impulse is a form of liberation from that discipline and control.¹⁴ As long as we believe this, we have no reason to question the ways the institutions of our society channel us into narrow corners of liberation and in actuality succeed in “managing” us even more. (Rousseau argued that women could never be

citizens because they could not discipline, control, and sublimate their sexuality.)

This is a very pessimistic view. Another dimension of the social I would like to explore is how people, in turn, resist their management by technologies of power-knowledge. One way might be through a cultural studies approach. As Stuart Hall says, there is something at stake in cultural studies ("Cultural Studies," 278)—and perhaps what is at stake is human liberation from the various ways we are managed, controlled, surveilled, that is, the ways we are interpellated by **ideology**. A kind of liberation can be at least partially achieved through a critical analysis of our culture and the ways different domains of life interconnect, through the production and practice of critical knowledge. This means questioning our own assumptions every bit as much as we question the assumptions of others and of the cultural objects we examine and analyze. Hall argues that one of the goals of cultural studies is the formation of the organic intellectual (a term that comes from Gramsci) and the development of intellectual and theoretical work as a political practice (281).¹⁵

After Hall presented his paper, a conference attendee asked him whether he was proposing an elite model of learning, where people are divided into a class of intellectuals who do the analyzing, on the one hand, and the rest of us, on the other (290). **But cultural studies attempts to work against this model of an elite class of educated people that holds knowledge and rules the world with the extra knowledge it has.** The idea, then, would be to develop a kind of knowledge and critical practice that all could share. This is why, as hooks and Wallace point out, popular culture is so useful.¹⁶ Everyone already does share it as an arena of cultural contestation and discussion. Recent political debates in the United States and debates about censorship and public funding for so-called obscene art have centered around artifacts of popular culture: debates on important social issues have arisen as a result of Madonna, the rap group 2 Live Crew, Spike Lee, Sistah Souljah, *Murphy Brown*, Ice-T, gangsta rap. These popular culture texts have been at the center of nationwide critical debates about sexuality, motherhood, racism, homophobia, freedom of speech, pornography, cultural differences, and multiculturalism.

Toward the end of his essay on the theoretical legacies of cultural studies, Hall expresses a fear that if cultural studies becomes too institutionalized—particularly as it has done in the United States—it might begin to ignore questions of power, history, and politics.¹⁷ hooks also echoes this concern: “Many academics involved with cultural studies do not see their work as emerging from an oppositional, progressive, cultural politic that seeks to link theory and practice, that has as its most central agenda sharing knowledge and information in ways that transform how we think about our social reality” (*Yearning*, 6). On the other hand, she also endorses cultural studies analyses of popular culture:

Much postmodern engagement with culture emerges from the yearning to do intellectual work that connects with habits of being, forms of artistic expression, and aesthetics that inform the daily life of writers and scholars as well as a mass population. On the terrain of culture, one can participate in critical dialogue with the uneducated poor, the black underclass who are thinking about aesthetics. One can talk about what we are seeing, thinking, or listening to; a space is there for critical exchange. It's exciting to think, write, talk about, and create art that reflects passionate engagement with popular culture, because this may very well be “the” central future location of resistance struggle, a meeting place where new and radical happenings can occur. (31)

My position, like theirs, is both hopeful and skeptical: when we talk about mass culture or electronic culture, we are talking about a culture enmeshed in systems of mass production and consumption, multinational corporations and systems of international capital. This knowledge tempers any excessive optimism about the progressive potentials of popular cultural representations, reminding us that all these cultural productions are involved to some extent in technologies of social control.

Political positioning is clearly crucial to cultural studies; in the case of the present work, it will be clear that I occupy a particular political position rather than posing as neutral or bias-free in my analysis of the cultural texts in question. Thus, some of the critiques may raise political objections from readers. There is no question that cultural studies as a whole, with a history of Marxist and otherwise oppositional critique, has

a leftist political agenda at its core, and it would not make sense to pretend that that is not the case. But to be oppositional and progressive or to have as one's goal social change does not mean giving up rigorous analysis and lucid critique, as is implied in the term "political correctness." In a context where the hegemonic culture is right-leaning, being oppositional raises a challenge to be even more critical, even more lucid, even more self-questioning than those in power, who do not have similar stakes in social change. It is not enough to assert that something is so—it must be argued in ways that persuade or convince.

In teaching cultural studies, hooks asks,

Am I educating the colonizer/oppressor class so that they can better exert control? . . . [my friend] says that we can only respond to this circumstance by assuming a radical standpoint and radicalizing students so that they learn to think critically, so that they do not perpetuate domination, so that they do not support colonialism and imperialism, but do understand the meaning of resistance. (132)

This is an ambitious project that no theoretical enterprise could hope to accomplish without an activist practice to test it, and this is perhaps the greatest classroom challenge to an intellectual endeavor that sees progressive political change and intervention as one of its goals: the U.S. college classroom does not easily accommodate activism. Given the constraints, "critical thinking" may nevertheless prove invaluable, and achievable; in other words, universities today are still in a position to promote this aspect of participatory democracy.

Critical analysis can be assisted by practices of close reading; close reading here means noticing everything in a text, but it also means not adding "speculation," "psychology," or our own opinions, beliefs, and ideology to that text. It means, in other words, making an argument about meaning based on evidence that can be found in the representation itself. Critical self-awareness in this regard means knowing the difference between reading what is there and adding something to a text from one's own intellectual and experiential baggage. This is not to say that one's own opinions and speculations have no value, but that it is important to distinguish between those and what is in the

text itself. This is a very difficult distinction to make in practice, not the least because public discussions in our culture almost never do. For example, if Sistah Souljah says, “whites beware,” Bill Clinton translates that as “Sistah Souljah counsels blacks to hate whites”; this is an example of what I call ideological reading (to be distinguished from a reading that is attentive to ideology), reading something into a statement that is not there.¹⁸ The exercise of critical analysis is, rather, about exploring the possible meanings of what *is* there, delaying, in other words, the tendency to use a representation to promote one’s own ideology, beliefs, and prejudices.¹⁹

B. Serial Killers and the Question of Representation

I want to begin with a popular genre of representation in mainstream culture, the serial killer story, to illustrate some of what might be included in a cultural studies approach to popular culture, specifically in relation to film. I refer to three films in particular, *Dressed to Kill* (Brian de Palma, 1980), *The Silence of the Lambs* (Jonathan Demme, 1991), and *Basic Instinct* (Paul Verhoeven, 1992), which, because of the fame of their actors or directors, became **crossover** films that appealed to and were viewed by a wider audience than the usual “horror” genre fans. These three films bring together a nexus of concerns that relate to mainstream culture’s anxieties around violence in the culture, feminism, and newly recognized sexual subcultures and sexualities.

A cultural studies discussion of films such as *Basic Instinct* focuses on aspects of the film that would not necessarily be covered by a strict film studies analysis, and does not look at this film as one would for a film studies class. Questions of formal genre (such as how *Basic Instinct* is a camp “anthology” of the **film noir** genre, citing Hitchcock, among others) and its relation to the classic police detective narrative, while relevant, do not constitute the main focus of my discussion. Instead, I would propose looking at how *Basic Instinct* puts gender roles into play; for example, one could situate this film in the context of the women’s movements of the last twenty years and explore the way it seems to react to those movements by talking about how women have

become rich, dangerous, and educated (both Catherine and Elizabeth, the film's heroines, have master's degrees from Berkeley) at the expense of "ordinary" (working-class) white guys.

Basic Instinct is an interesting film to consider in the context of cultural politics because it was the object of intense debate about questions of gender and sexuality. The film offers us a representation of bisexuality or lesbianism, and it has served as an occasion for debates about the representation of gays and lesbians in the media, debates that often take the form of interrogating whether a particular representation is "good" or "bad" (politically, socially) for the people it represents. But as I mentioned, such debates do not ultimately analyze the representation in question. In the case of *Basic Instinct*, what seems to get represented most around the question of bisexuality or lesbianism is its exclusionary nature, the way it refuses domination or control or access by straight men. This movie tells us a lot, in a tongue-in-cheek way, about straight male anxiety and paranoia—in other words, we laugh at the male hysteria in this film even as we share it. Is this because, as some read the movie's ending, there is really nothing to worry about from the in-control, bisexual woman, because she is really just like any other woman and will fall in love with you (the straight white male) and submit to you, if only you prove yourself strong enough and persistent enough? This is the conclusion one arrives at if the ending is read as a narrative of domestication, that is, that the protagonist decides not to kill Nick because she loves him. Or does the movie really empower the independent woman who resists such control, and argue that indeed men are fascinated by the risky link between sex and death? If we follow this interpretation, then the "basic instinct" in this movie seems to be both the sexual instinct and the instinct to kill or to risk death, so that we could also see this movie as a kind of allegory about sex in the age of AIDS, imagining that the risk of death adds excitement (by adding lethal danger) to the question of sex.

Some of the popular debates about this film's "feminism" involved questions about the motives of representation: for example, is the portrayal of a rape tantamount to condoning rape? A representation is not automatically a recommendation. For example, some people argued that the portrayal of Nick forcibly having sex with Beth (Elizabeth)

made *Basic Instinct* an antifeminist film. This statement does not, however, provide us with enough contextual information to come to such a conclusion. One would have to argue that the film suggests that force was justified, that Nick was right, in other words, to do what he did. I think one needs to make that case in order to argue that the film lends consent to the notion of rape.

Many people argued the antifeminism or homophobia of *Basic Instinct* on the basis of its representation of lesbians as pathologically angry murderers and drug users. But when one analyzes systems of sexual difference as they are represented in the culture, it is important not to isolate one side of the term in one's analysis. In other words, how is Nick represented in the film? Is he the good guy? Are white men good in the film? What does it mean that he is represented the way he is? It is also important to locate the subjectivity of the film, to figure out whose point of view is privileged and how this shapes our reactions, responses, and interpretations. Asking questions like these is a way into a cultural studies analysis of a mass media-produced visual text. How does the text speak about the social context that produces it? Does it challenge dominant ideas in the culture? What I am interested in here are the possibilities and limits of such texts.

In serial killer films we also witness a certain construction of a sexual category—the homosexual—and the traces of its longtime association with sexual **perversion**. The serial killer is a study in psychopathic perversion: he is usually a man with a sexual dysfunction, and in the eighties and nineties this has come to be associated predominantly in public culture with some form of homosexuality. The films mentioned—*Dressed to Kill*, *The Silence of the Lambs*, and *Basic Instinct*—demonstrate a newfound and self-conscious awareness of this identity category, an awareness based in recent efforts by gays and lesbians to win recognition and civil rights. It is just such an awareness that makes these films interesting as symptoms of mainstream culture's reaction to post-Stonewall political struggles for visibility, for they uneasily negotiate between “healthy” and “pathological” constructions of gay identity.

Dressed to Kill introduces a “new” category of socially recognized pervert, related in the culture's mind to homosexuality: the transsexual man. In the film, the multiple personality of the killer is split between the one

who wants to be a woman and the one who wants to stay a man. The one who wants to be a woman becomes a killer each time the man becomes sexually aroused as a man (the framework is **heterosexist** throughout, that is, it equates heterosexual desire with “being a man”). The problem, says the movie, is when you cannot make up your mind which you are or want to be. At the end of the movie, the biomedical technology of sex change operations is described luridly to the teenage male heroic protagonist of the film by the gutsy call girl who also solves the mystery. The audience is supposed to regard this procedure as monstrous.

In *The Silence of the Lambs*, the message has become more subtle: the problem is not authentic transsexualism or gender dysphoria, **but the mistake of thinking that you want to be a woman when you are—and really wish to remain—a man.** This film, in turn, confuses the categories of the gay person and the transsexual and suggests to us (through the name of the dog, Precious, and through the history of the killer and his male lover) that being gay, if you are a man, is the same as wanting to be a woman. Although the film hides behind the “mistake” that confuses the killer Jamie Gum (“Buffalo Bill”), it nevertheless invites our **voyeuristic** fascination with sexual subcultures: Jamie’s dressing up, his hiding his penis between his legs and his mirror-image **drag queen** poses, his makeup, and of course, most obviously, his nipple ring all conjure up images of gay subcultural “lifestyles.” These images collapse icons and elements of various sexual subcultures into a nexus that links homosexuality, transsexualism, female impersonation, perversion, and killing. *Basic Instinct* also displays confusion regarding the sexual subculture it purports to reference, although one might argue that this movie does not deal with being gay as a subcultural phenomenon, but rather isolates the lesbians/bisexuals, so that one does not have the impression of a culture that supports them at all.

Amy Taubin makes an argument about how and why serial killer stories are so popular in the United States:

With just 5% of the world's population, the US is believed to have about 75% of the world's serial killers.

Disturbing as these figures are, the fact is that the number of people who will die at the hands of serial killers doesn't even bear comparison with, for example, the number of women who will die because they

don't have access to breast screening, or even know it exists. But institutionalized violence—the destruction of millions of lives through poverty and neglect, the abuse practiced against women and children, the slaughter of 100,000 Iraqis—has no easy representation. The stage of the serial killer acts as a substitute and a shield for a situation so incomprehensible and threatening it must be disavowed.²⁰

The popular fascination with random, illogical, and individual psychologically motivated violence is a reassuring fiction for people because it does not focus our attention on institutionalized social violence—violence that is motivated by reasons we see all too clearly (poverty, discrimination, etc.). At the same time, we acknowledge, on some subconscious level, that violence saturates our social order; but we displace it from its economic and political roots onto the figure of the psycho serial killer. This is one of the meanings of “seriality”: the repeated nature of the violence points beyond the isolated incidents of violence toward the notion that violence, in our culture, is pervasive and repeated.

In order to further develop this issue of the “privatization” or “individualization” of violence that Taubin claims motivates the fascination with serial killers, we may find it useful to sketch the historical development of the ideology of liberal individualism. To call individualism an ideology is to argue that one must account—historically, as well as in other ways—for a phenomenon that, when we see it enacted in representation, presents itself to us as self-evident reality.

The liberal **bourgeois** political tradition, which was developed in Europe in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries and corresponds on an intimate level to the economic system known as **capitalism**, constructs individuals as the primary entity in society. This represents a kind of cellular view of the body politic, where the whole is made up of autonomous, almost self-sufficient and independent entities who, acting together, form the whole body and motivate its actions. In fact, some feminist historians of evolutionary biology, such as Evelyn Fox Keller, have launched a critique against just this picture of the functioning of the human body, pointing out that it is not possible to take a cellular view of living organisms because most of them, particularly humans, never function in a way that isolates one cell. Cells are part of

a system, and so to talk about them in isolation (the way, for example, sociobiologists talk about “the selfish gene”) is an ideological notion derived from the bourgeois political tradition, one that conceives of humans as isolated individual beings who together, but also independently, make up what we call society.²¹

People are never found apart from a social order, and there is no such thing as an isolated individual. Yet our political tradition, our laws, our political philosophies assume precisely this model of humanity. Karl Marx argued that economics is always a political economy, that people exist in societies that have overall economic systems organizing the whole of the social order. He argued that we need to organize our economies as systematic and collective means for producing, distributing, and consuming the resources of groups of people, with a view to providing for the group, since it is only by virtue of our grouping together—our social existence, in other words—that we have economies. We do not live in isolation and we can collectively plan for the provision of the group. Yet classical economics (what motivates capitalism’s economic philosophy) acts as though people are individual agents in individual economic transactions, even though all of us are wholly interdependent. And a corporation (you can even hear it in the word—from *corpus* or body) is simply viewed as a macrocosm of individuals.²²

Thus, even though economics are completely interdependent and interrelated, we think of economic transactions as isolated events, actions committed by autonomous individuals acting as free agents in their own interests, as though each of us only coincidentally lived next to each other, and our existence was in some fundamental way independent from the existence or survival of other humans. Today, of course, we critique this notion with arguments about our entire interrelatedness, not just to other human beings, but also to organic life as a whole system: animals, plants, and the earth.

I have been making this argument to show how individualism produces a specific way of conceptualizing human beings and their interrelations in society that is not necessarily the truth of our social existence. We are never not social. Yet the way we talk about individuals assumes that people can be thought of as autonomous, independent, isolated, and above all—and this seems to be one of the greatest ruses of individualism—free.

Serial killers typify this individualistic conception of violence, as being located in a body, a single individual, as having primarily psychic causes, having to do with a private history, and as posing a very individualized threat to each and every one of us. The solution to the problem of violence, then, also becomes individual and private.²³ In serial killer stories we learn that the source of violence and disorder in the individual stems from his family, a family that is similarly dysfunctional for reasons not construed as social or political. The sources of pathology are located in a family history, a family romance, separable somehow from the rest of what goes on in the social order.²⁴

Another contemporary example of this phenomenon of the privatization of violence is the recent focus on "child abuse" as the cause and source of our psychosexual disorders in contemporary U.S. society. This is represented in the movie *The Silence of the Lambs*, when Dr. Lecter says that Buffalo Bill was not born, but made, through years of systematic childhood abuse. Child abuse theories often seem to argue that we become monsters because of something that happens within the private sphere of the family. The person responsible is a specific, localizable individual: one or both of our parents is directly responsible, in other words, for the monsters we turn out to be. This is a picture of society that implies that we begin our lives and grow up in isolated private cells called families, disconnected from the rest of the social order and, indeed, from the rest of the world. At a certain point in our lives we then emerge into the public, bringing with us the damage done to us in this thing called the family. I am exaggerating somewhat, but I do so to show how these theories have a particular and ideologically specific view of the world that does not necessarily correspond to something we might want to call truth, and that they are theories with interested ideologies, that is, they tell a story of the way things are and present that story as self-evident reality. All stories are constructed: they are all particular versions of "the way things are," and they limit the possibilities of other stories being told even as they permit certain conclusions to be drawn.

What interests do these ideologies of violence serve? What are the implications and the consequences if we think of violence as something that originates in the private sphere, as a result of the actions of isolated individuals upon other isolated individuals (especially if it

happened when those individuals were children)? What are the implications for dealing with the question of what Taubin calls “institutionalized violence” in the social order? What do they say about what the problem is, and what the solution to the problem might be? In the case of serial killers, individuals who threaten other individuals, the solution seems relatively simple: kill the serial killer and your problem goes away.

According to Taubin,

Unlike urban action pictures, which imply that the threat to America is ghettoised, serial killer films are set in white neighborhoods—suburbia, the farm belt, the back woods. And in fact, almost all serial killers are white males who kill within their own racial group. Bred in the heartlands, he's the deformed version of the American dream of the individual. (16)

What does it mean to locate the “deformation” of the American dream not in corrupt government, in economic institutions that exploit us, or in systemic corruption, but in an individual?

If this is the general gist of serial killer narratives, then how does *The Silence of the Lambs* buttress this view of the world and the sources of violence in U.S. society, and how does it depart from the model outlined? Can this departure be at all described as progressive? Taubin wants to make the argument that *The Silence of the Lambs* is doing something special with this narrative by suggesting what we already know: that violence in our society is not a primarily individualized thing, that it is not only located in specific individuals with localizable and private sources, but in a whole legacy and history of American culture.

The Silence of the Lambs is, Taubin remarks, “packed with 300 years of relics—of white America. Every time Lecter sends Clarice on a treasure hunt—to a storage warehouse for example—she finds a flag or two tucked away with the rusty rifles, dressmakers’ dummies and the odd severed head preserved in a jar. The flags look as though they’ve seen better days.”

Near the end of the film, in the aftermath of Clarice’s battle with Buffalo Bill, the camera lingers for a moment in a corner of the killer’s lair,

now lit with a shaft of light from a window broken in the struggle. First, there's a medium shot of a child's size American flag leaning against a dusty army helmet and then a close-up of a sea-blue paper mobile with a butterfly design—a bit of Chinatown interior decoration or a trophy from Viet Nam. Bill's inheritance and his legacy. Which is why the final image of Lecter after his murderous escape, sauntering down a crowded main street in Haiti [*sic*] resplendent in his creamy tourist suit, is more disturbing than anything that has come before. The serial killer, an American gift to the third world, a fragmentation bomb, ready to explode. (16)

Taubin's interpretation brings into view a possibly progressive, political reading of this film. This is what is meant by the term **disavowal** and how it functions: one knows that something is true, but one refuses that knowledge and constructs a cover story for that which one refuses to know. Thus one both knows and does not know "the truth." To foreground disavowal as a structure within representation allows us to identify and discuss this recognition of institutionalized violence in our culture and makes it possible to link stories of individualized pathology to the social.